Playing It Safe

Illustration Shyam Shriram

Never underplay the need for a backup solution. Find one suited to ***your*** needs

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A computer is the single most complicated piece of equipment we use. It has moving parts, magnetic storage, heat dissipation, and has to contend with fallible operating systems and software. Today, critical data stored on a computer connected to the Internet has a lower probability of survival than a kitten crossing a busy highway. All this we are well aware of. We have all been inducted into the religion of backups—either through articles like this one, or due to prior, horrendous data loss encounters. What we don't realise, however, is that every office has different needs. What's good for the goose is not necessarily good for the gander.

Subjective Selections

Every office has its own requirements—you may be spending too little or too much on your data backups. So what are your requirements?

The first step towards identifying a solution is to identify your needs. The first thing you need to do is analyse the amount of critical data that needs to be backed up. Once you have a clearer picture of your data, you can segregate the data into three broad categories.

The first is data that is used on an everyday basis, and needs to be backed up more than a couple of times a day, such as databases. The second is data that might be needed about once a week, and will be modified. The third is data that no one needs more than once a month (or even a year), and might or might not be modified, such as invoice archives for tax purposes.

You have to put your business, and the data it generates and uses, under the microscope and figure out what data fits into which category.

Depending on the volume of data to be backed up in each case, you can come to a solution.

Most businesses already have file servers or network servers that act as a critical data repository. Because of the large amount of reading and writing—and the resulting heat—that servers' disks are subject to, they are prone to failure. What you need to do is get a backup option for these servers. We look at some of the backup technologies available, and what needs they might fulfil.

Definitions

DAT: Digital Audio Tape; has a maximum capacity of 40 GB and offers data transfer speeds of 19 GB per hour

DLT / SDLT: Digital Linear Tape/Super DLT; has a maximum capacity of 320 GB and offers data transfer speeds of 115 GB per hour

AIT: Advanced Intelligent Tape; has a maximum capacity of 260 GB and offers data transfer speeds of 112 GB per hour

LTO (Ultrium): Linear Tape Open; has a maximum capacity of 400 GB and offers data transfer speeds of 216 GB per hour